

Monk, in this conversation, convinced himself of one thing, which he must have remarked after the first words exchanged: that was, that he had to deal with a man of high distinction. He could not be an assassin, and it was repugnant to Monk to believe him to be a spy; but there was sufficient finesse and at the same time firmness in Athos to lead Monk to fancy he was a conspirator. When they had quitted the table, 'You still believe in your treasure, then, monsieur?' asked Monk.

'Yes, my lord.'

'Quite seriously?'

'Seriously.'

'And you think you can find the place again where it was buried?'

'At the first inspection.'

'Well, monsieur, from curiosity I shall accompany you. And it is so much the more necessary that I should accompany you, that you would find great difficulties in passing through the camp without me or one of my lieutenants.'

'General, I would not suffer you to inconvenience yourself if I did not, in fact, stand in need of your company; but as I recognize that this company is not only honourable, but necessary, I accept it.'

'Do you desire we should take any people with us?' asked Monk.

'General, I believe that would be useless, if you yourself do not see the necessity for it. Two men and a horse will suffice to transport the two casks on board the felucca which brought me hither.'

'But it will be necessary to pick, dig, and remove the earth, and split stones; you don't intend doing this work yourself, monsieur, do you?'

'General, there is no picking or digging required. The treasure is buried in the sepulchral vault of the convent, under a stone in which is fixed a large iron ring, and under which there are four steps leading down. The two casks are there, placed end to end, covered with a coat of plaster in the form of a bier. There is, besides, an inscription, which will enable me to recognize the stone; and as I am not willing, in an affair of delicacy and confidence, to keep the secret from your honour, here is the inscription:—"Hic jacet venerabilis, Petrus Gulielmus Scott, Canon Honorab. Conventus Novi Castellii. Obiit quarta et decima Feb. ann. Dom. MCCVIII. Requiescat in pace."

Monk did not lose a single word. He was astonished either at the marvellous duplicity of this man and the superior style in which he played his part, or

at the good loyal faith with which he presented his request, in a situation in which concerning a million of money, risked against the blow from a dagger, amidst an army that would have looked upon the theft as a restitution.

'Very well,' said he; 'I shall accompany you; and the adventure appears to me so wonderful, that I shall carry the torch myself.' And saying these words, he girded on a short sword, placed a pistol in his belt, disclosing in this movement, which opened his doublet a little, the fine rings of a coat of mail, destined to protect him from the first dagger-thrust of an assassin. After which he took a Scottish dirk in his left hand, and then turning to Athos, 'Are you ready, monsieur?' said he.

'I am.'

Athos, as if in opposition to what Monk had done, unfastened his poniard, which he placed upon the table; unhooked his sword-belt, which he laid close to his poniard; and, without affectation, opening his doublet as if to look for his handkerchief, showed beneath his fine cambric shirt his naked breast, without weapons either offensive or defensive.

'This is truly a singular man,' said Monk; 'he is without any arms; he has an ambuscade placed somewhere yonder.'

'General,' said he, as if he had divined Monk's thought, 'you wish we should be alone; that is very right, but a great captain ought never to expose himself with temerity. It is night, the passage of the marsh may present dangers; be accompanied.'

'You are right,' replied he, calling Digby. The aid-de-camp appeared. 'Fifty men with swords and muskets,' said he, looking at Athos.

'That is too few if there is danger, too many if there is not.'

'I will go alone,' said Monk; 'I want nobody. Come, monsieur.'

'I assure you, my lord,' he said firmly, 'that my conviction is, that the two barrels have neither changed place nor master.' This reply had removed one suspicion from the mind of Monk, but it had suggested another. Without doubt this Frenchman was some emissary sent to entice into error the protector of the parliament; the gold was nothing but a lure; and by the help of this lure they thought to excite the cupidity of the general. This gold might not exist. It was Monk's business, then, to seize the Frenchman in the act of falsehood and trick, and to draw from the false step itself in which his enemies wished to entrap him, a triumph for his renown. When Monk was determined how to act,—

'Monsieur,' said he to Athos, 'without doubt you will do me the honour to share my supper this evening?'

'Yes, my lord,' replied Athos, bowing; 'for you do me an honour of which I feel myself worthy, by the inclination which drew me towards you.'

'It is so much the more gracious on your part to accept my invitation with such frankness, as my cooks are but few and inexperienced, and my providers have returned this evening empty-handed; so that if it had not been for a fisherman of your nation who strayed into our camp, General Monk would have gone to bed without his supper to-day; I have, then, some fresh fish to offer you, as the vendor assures me.'

'My lord, it is principally for the sake of having the honour to pass an hour with you.'

After this exchange of civilities, during which Monk had lost nothing of his circumspection, the supper, or what was to serve for one, had been laid upon a deal table. Monk invited the Comte de la Fère to be seated at this table, and took his place opposite to him. A single dish of boiled fish, set before the two illustrious guests, was more tempting to hungry stomachs than to delicate palates.

Whilst supping, that is, while eating the fish, washed down with bad ale, Monk got Athos to relate to him the last events of the Fronde, the reconciliation of M. de Condé with the king, and the probable marriage of the infant of Spain; but he avoided, as Athos himself avoided it, all allusion to the political interests which united, or rather which disunited at this time, England, France and Holland.

remained interred there, and I have come to entreat your honour to permit me to withdraw it before, perhaps, the battle turning that way, a mine or some other war engine has destroyed the building and scattered my gold, or rendered it so apparent that the soldiers will take possession of it.'

Monk was well acquainted with mankind; he saw in the physiognomy of this gentleman all the energy, all the reason, all the circumspection possible; he could therefore only attribute to a magnanimous confidence the revelation the Frenchman had made him, and he showed himself profoundly touched by it.

'Monsieur,' said he, 'you have augured well of me. But is the sum worth the trouble to which you expose yourself? Do you even believe that it can be in the same place where you left it?'

'It is there monsieur, I do not doubt.'

'That is a reply to one question; but to the other. I asked you if the sum was so large as to warrant your exposing yourself thus.'

'It is really large; yes, my lord, for it is a million I inclosed in two barrels.'

'A million!' cried Monk, at whom this time, in turn, Athos looked earnestly and long. Monk perceived this, and his mistrust returned.

'Here is a man,' said he to himself, 'who is laying a snare for me. So you wish to withdraw this money, monsieur,' replied he, 'as I understand?'

'If you please, my lord.'

'To-day?'

'This very evening, and that on account of the circumstances I have named.'

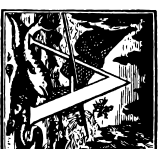
'But, monsieur,' objected Monk, 'General Lambert is as near the Abbey where you have to act as I am. Why, then, have you not addressed yourself to him?'

'Because, my lord, when one acts in important matters, it is best to consult one's instinct before everything. Well, General Lambert does not inspire with me so much confidence as you do.'

'Be it so, monsieur. I shall assist you in recovering your money, if, however, it can still be there; for that is far from likely. Since 1648 twelve years have rolled away, and many events have taken place.' Monk dwelt upon this point to see if the French gentleman would seize the evasions that were open to him, but Athos did not hesitate.

Chapter XXV

The Marsh



ATHOS and Monk passed over, in going from the camp towards the Tweed, that part of the ground which Digby had traversed with the fishermen coming from the Tweed to the camp. The aspect of this place, the aspect of the changes man had wrought in it, was of a nature to produce a great effect upon a lively and delicate imagination like that of Athos. Athos looked at nothing but these desolate spots; Monk looked at nothing but Athos—at Athos, who, with his eyes sometimes directed towards heaven, and sometimes towards the earth, sought, thought, and sighed.

Digby, whom the last orders of the general, and particularly the accent with which he had given them, had at first a little excited, Digby followed the pair at about twenty paces, but the general having turned round as if astonished to find his orders had not been obeyed, the aid-de-camp perceived his indiscretion, and returned to his tent.

He supposed that the general wished to make, incognito, one of those reviews of vigilance which every experienced captain never fails to make on the eve of a decisive engagement: he explained to himself the presence of Athos in this case as an inferior explains all that is mysterious on the part of his leader. Athos might be, and, indeed, in the eyes of Digby, must be, a spy, whose information was to enlighten the general.

At the end of a walk of about ten minutes among the tents and posts, which were closer together near the headquarters, Monk entered upon a little causeway which diverged into three branches. That on the left led to the river, that in the middle to Newcastle Abbey on the marsh, that on the right crossed the first lines of Monk's camp; that is to say, the lines nearest to Lambert's

army. Beyond the river was an advanced post, belonging to Monk's army, which watched the enemy; it was composed of one hundred and fifty Scots. They had swum across the Tweed, and, in case of attack, were to recross it in the same manner, giving the alarm; but as there was no post at that spot, and as Lambert's soldiers were not so prompt at taking to the water as Monk's were, the latter appeared not to have as much uneasiness on that side. On this side of the river, at about five hundred paces from the old Abbey, the fishermen had taken up their abode amidst a crowd of small tents raised by soldiers of the neighbouring clans, who had with them their wives and children. All this confusion, seen by the moon's light, presented a striking coup d'œil; the half shadow enlarged every detail, and the light, that flatterer which only attaches itself to the polished side of things, courted upon each rusty musket the point still left intact, and upon every rag of canvas the whitest and least sullied part.

Monk arrived then with Athos, crossing this spot, illumined with a double light, the silver splendour of the moon, and the red blaze of the fires at the meeting of these three causeways; there he stopped, and addressing his companion, — 'Monsieur,' said he, 'do you know your road?'

'General, if I am not mistaken, the middle causeway leads straight to the Abbey.'

'That is right; but we shall want lights to guide us in the vaults.' Monk turned round.

'Ah! I thought Digby was following us!' said he. 'So much the better; he will procure us what we want.'

'Yes, general, there is a man yonder who has been walking behind us for some time.'

'Digby?' cried Monk. 'Digby! come here, if you please.'

But instead of obeying, the shadow made a motion of surprise, and, retreating instead of advancing, it bent down and disappeared along the jetty on the left, directing its course towards the lodging of the fishermen.

'It appears not to be Digby,' said Monk.

Both had followed the shadow which had vanished. But it was not so rare a thing for a man to be wandering about at eleven o'clock at night, in a camp in which are reposing ten or eleven thousand men, as to give Monk and Athos any alarm at his disappearance.

'What dignity?'

'King Charles I made me a knight of the Garter, and Queen Anne of Austria has given me the cordon of the Holy Ghost. These are my only dignities.'

'The Garter! the Holy Ghost! Are you a knight of those two orders, monsieur?'

'Yes.'

'And on what occasions have such favours been bestowed upon you?'

'For services rendered to their majesties.'

Monk looked with astonishment at this man, who appeared to him so simple and so great at the same time. Then, as if he had renounced endeavouring to penetrate this mystery of a simplicity and grandeur upon which the stranger did not seem disposed to give him any other information than that which he had already received, — 'Did you present yourself yesterday at our advanced posts?'

'And was sent back? Yes, my lord.'

'Many officers, monsieur, would permit no one to enter their camp, particularly on the eve of a probable battle. But I differ from my colleagues, and like to leave nothing behind me. Every advice is good to me; all danger is sent to me by God, and I weigh it in my hand with the energy He has given me. So, yesterday, you were only sent back on account of the council I was holding. To-day I am at liberty,—speak.'

'My lord, you have done much better in receiving me, for what I have to say has nothing to do with the battle you are about to fight with General Lambert, or with your camp; and the proof is, that I turned away my head that I might not see your men, and closed my eyes that I might not count your tents. No, I came to speak to you, my lord, on my own account.'

'Speak then, monsieur,' said Monk.

'Just now,' continued Athos, 'I had the honour of telling your lordship that for a long time I lived in Newcastle; it was in the time of Charles I, and when the king was given up to Cromwell by the Scots.'

'I know,' said Monk, coldly.

'I had at that time a large sum in gold, and on the eve of the battle, from a presentiment perhaps of the turn which things would take on the morrow, I concealed it in the principal vault of the covenant of Newcastle, in the tower whose summit you now see silvered by the moonbeams. My treasure has then

'There is nothing surprising, my lord, in my speaking English tolerably; I resided for some time in England in my youth, and since then I have made two voyages to this country.' These words were spoken in French, and with a purity of accent that bespoke not only a Frenchman, but a Frenchman from the vicinity of Tours.

'And what part of England have you resided in, monsieur?'

'In my youth, London, my lord; then, about 1635, I made a pleasure trip to Scotland; and lastly, in 1648, I lived for some time at Newcastle, particularly in the convent, the gardens of which are now occupied by your army.'

'Excuse me, monsieur; but you must comprehend that these questions are necessary on my part—do you not?'

'It would astonish me, my lord, if they were not asked.'

'Now, then, monsieur, what can I do to serve you? What do you wish?'

'This, my lord;—but, in the first place, are we alone?'

'Perfectly so, monsieur, except, of course, the post which guards us.' So saying, Monk pulled open the canvas with his hand, and pointed to the soldier placed at ten paces from the tent, and who, at the first call, could have rendered assistance in a second.

'In that case, my lord,' said the gentleman, in as calm a tone as if he had been for a length of time in habits of intimacy with his interlocutor, 'I have made up my mind to address myself to you, because I believe you to be an honest man. Indeed, the communication I am about to make to you will prove to you the esteem in which I hold you.'

Monk, astonished at this language, which established between him and the French gentleman equality at least, raised his piercing eye to the stranger's face, and with a sensible irony conveyed by the inflection of his voice alone, for not a muscle of his face moved,—'I thank you, monsieur,' said he; 'but, in the first place, to whom have I the honour of speaking?'

'I sent you my name by your sergeant, my lord.'

'Excuse him, monsieur, he is a Scotsman,—he could not retain it.'

'I am called the Comte de la Fère, monsieur,' said Athos, bowing.

'The Comte de la Fère?' said Monk, endeavouring to recollect the name.

'Pardon me, monsieur, but this appears to be the first time I have ever heard that name. Do you fill any post at the court of France?'

'None; I am a simple gentleman.'

'As it is so,' said Monk, 'and we must have a light, a lantern, a torch, or something by which we may see where to see our feet; let us seek this light.'

'General, the first soldier we meet will light us.'

'No,' said Monk, in order to discover if there were not any connivance between the Comte de la Fère and the fisherman. 'No, I should prefer one of these French sailors who came this evening to sell me their fish. They leave to-morrow, and the secret will be better kept by them; whereas, if a report should be spread in the Scottish army, that treasures are to be found in the Abbey of Newcastle, my Highlanders will believe there is a million concealed beneath every slab, and they will not leave stone upon stone in the building.'

'Do as you think best, general,' replied Athos, in a natural tone of voice, making evident that soldier or fisherman was the same to him, and that he had no preference.

Monk approached the causeway behind which had disappeared the person he had taken for Digby, and met a patrol who, making the tour of the tents, was going towards headquarters; he was stopped with his companion, gave the password, and went on. A soldier, roused by the noise, unrolled his plaid, and looked up to see what was going forward. 'Ask him,' said Monk to Athos, 'where the fishermen are; if I were to speak to him, he would know me.'

Athos went up to the soldier, who pointed out the tent to him; immediately Monk and Athos turned towards it. It appeared to the general that at the moment they came up, a shadow like that they had already seen, glided into this tent; but on drawing nearer he perceived he must have been mistaken, for all of them were asleep *pele mele*, and nothing was seen but arms and legs joined, crossed, and mixed. Athos, fearing lest he should be suspected of connivance with some of his compatriots, remained outside the tent.

'*Hola!*' said Monk, in French, 'wake up here.' Two or three of the sleepers got up.

'I want a man to light me,' continued Monk.

'Your honour may depend on us,' said a voice which made Athos start.

'Where do you wish us to go?'

'You shall see. A light! come, quickly!'

'Yes, your honour. Does it please your honour that I should accompany you?'

'You or another; it is of very little consequence, provided I have a light.'

'It is strange!' thought Athos, 'what a singular voice that man has!' 'Some fire, you fellows!' cried the fisherman; 'come, make haste!'

Then addressing his companion nearest to him in a low voice:—'Get ready a light, Menneville,' said he, 'and hold yourself ready for anything.'

One of the fishermen struck light from a stone, set fire to some tinder, and by the aid of a match lit a lantern. The light immediately spread all over the tent.

'Are you ready, monsieur?' said Monk to Athos, who had turned away, not to expose his face to the light.

'Yes, general,' replied he.

'Ah! the French gentleman!' said the leader of the fishermen to himself. '*Peste!* I have a great mind to charge you with the commission, Menneville; he may know me. Light! light!' This dialogue was pronounced at the back of the tent, and in so low a voice that Monk could not hear a syllable of it; he was, besides, talking with Athos. Menneville got himself ready in the meantime, or rather received the orders of his leader.

'Well?' said Monk.

'I am ready, general,' said the fisherman.

Monk, Athos, and the fisherman left the tent.

'It is impossible!' thought Athos. 'What dream could put that into my head?'

'Go forward; follow the middle causeway, and stretch out your legs,' said Monk to the fisherman.

They were not twenty paces on their way when the same shadow that had appeared to enter the tent came out of it again, crawled along as far as the piles, and, protected by that sort of parapet placed along the causeway, carefully observed the march of the general. All three disappeared in the night haze. They were walking towards Newcastle, the white stones of which appeared to them like sepulchres. After standing for a few seconds under the porch, they penetrated into the interior. The door had been broken open by hatchets. A post of four men slept in safety in a corner, so certain were they that the attack would not take place on that side.

'Will not these men be in your way?' said Monk to Athos.

'On the contrary, monsieur, they will assist in rolling out the barrels, if your honour will permit them.'

Chapter XXIV

The Treasure



THE French gentleman whom Spithhead had announced to Monk, and who, closely wrapped in his cloak, had passed by the fishermen who left the general's tent five minutes before he entered it,—the French gentleman went through the various posts without even casting his eyes around him, for fear of appearing indiscreet. As the order had been given, he was conducted to the tent of the general. The gentleman was left alone in the sort of ante-chamber in front of the principal body of the tent, where he awaited Monk, who only delayed till he had heard the report of his people, and observed through the opening of the canvas the countenance of the person who solicited an audience.

Without doubt, the report of those who had accompanied the French gentleman established the discretion with which he had behaved, for the first impression the stranger received of the welcome made him by the general was more favourable than he could have expected at such a moment, and on the part of so suspicious a man. Nevertheless, according to his custom, when Monk found himself in the presence of a stranger, he fixed upon him his penetrating eyes, which scrutiny, the stranger, on his part, sustained without embarrassment or notice. At the end of a few seconds, the general made a gesture with his hand and head in sign of attention.

'My lord,' said the gentleman, in excellent English, 'I have requested an interview with your honour, for an affair of importance.'

'Monsieur,' replied Monk, in French, 'you speak our language well for a son of the continent. I ask your pardon—for doubtless the question is indiscreet—do you speak French with the same purity?'

his companions, who were whispering with a volubility which did not appear exempt from uneasiness, but he made them a sign which seemed to reassure them. 'Hola, you fellows!' said the patron, 'come this way. His lordship, General Monk, has the generosity to pay us for our fish, and the goodness to give us hospitality for to-night.'

The fishermen gathered round their leader, and, conducted by Digby, the little troop proceeded towards the canteens, the post, as may be remembered, which had been assigned them. As they went along in the dark, the fishermen passed close to the guards who were conducting the French gentleman to General Monk. This gentleman was on horseback and enveloped in a large cloak, which prevented the patron from seeing him, however great his curiosity might be. As to the gentleman, ignorant that he was elbowing compatriots, he did not pay any attention to the little troop.

The aide-de-camp settled his guests in a tolerably comfortable tent, from which was dislodged an Irish canteen woman, who went, with her six children, to sleep where she could. A large fire was burning in front of this tent, and threw its purple light over the grassy pools of the marsh, rippled by a fresh breeze. The arrangements made, the aide-de-camp wished the fishermen good-night, calling to their notice that they might see from the door of the tent the masts of their bark, which was tossing gently on the Tweed, a proof that it had not yet sunk. The sight of this appeared to delight the leader of the fishermen infinitely.

'You are right.'

The post, though fast asleep, roused up at the first steps of the three visitors amongst the briars and grass that invaded the porch. Monk gave the password, and penetrated into the interior of the convent, preceded by the light. He walked last, watching the least movement of Athos, his naked dink in his sleeve, and ready to plunge it into the back of the gentleman at the first suspicious gesture he should see him make. But Athos, with a firm and sure step, crossed the chambers and cours.

Not a door, not a window was left in the building. The doors had been burnt, some on the spot, and the charcoal of them was still jagged with the action of the fire, which had gone out of itself, powerless, no doubt, to get to the heart of those massive joints of oak fastened together with iron nails. As to the windows, all the panes having been broken, night birds, alarmed by the torch, flew away through their holes. At the same time, gigantic bats began to trace their vast, silent circles around the intruders, whilst the light of the torch made their shadows tremble on the high stone walls. Monk concluded that there could be no man in the convent, since wild beasts and birds were there still, and fled away at his approach.

After having passed the rubbish, and torn away more than one branch of ivy that had made itself a guardian of the solitude, Athos arrived at the vaults situated beneath the great hall, but the entrance of which was from the chapel. There he stopped. 'Here we are, general,' said he.

'This, then, is the slab?'

'Yes.'

'Ay, and here is the ring—but the ring is sealed into the stone.'

'We must have a lever.'

'That's a very easy thing to find.'

Whilst looking around them, Athos and Monk perceived a little ash of about three inches in diameter, which had shot up in an angle of the wall, reaching a window, concealed by its branches.

'Have you a knife?' said Monk to the fisherman.

'Yes, monsieur.'

'Cut down this tree, then.'

good fellow and his companions to the little tents of the canteens, in front of the marshes, so that they will be near their bark, and yet will not sleep on board to-night. What is the matter, Spithead?

Spithead was the sergeant from whom Monk had borrowed a piece of tobacco for his supper. Spithead having entered the general's tent without being sent for, had drawn this question from Monk.

'My lord,' said he, 'a French gentleman has just presented himself at the outposts and wishes to speak to your honour.'

All this was said, be it understood, in English; but, notwithstanding, it produced a slight emotion in the fisherman, which Monk, occupied with his sergeant, did not remark.

'Who is the gentleman?' asked Monk.

'My lord,' replied Spithead, 'he told it me; but those devils of French names are so difficult to pronounce for a Scottish throat, that I could not retain it. I believe, however, from what the guards say, that it is the same gentleman who presented himself yesterday at the halt, and whom your honour would not receive.'

'That is true; I was holding a council of officers.'

'Will your honour give any orders respecting this gentleman?'

'Yes, let him be brought here.'

'Must we take any precautions?'

'Such as what?'

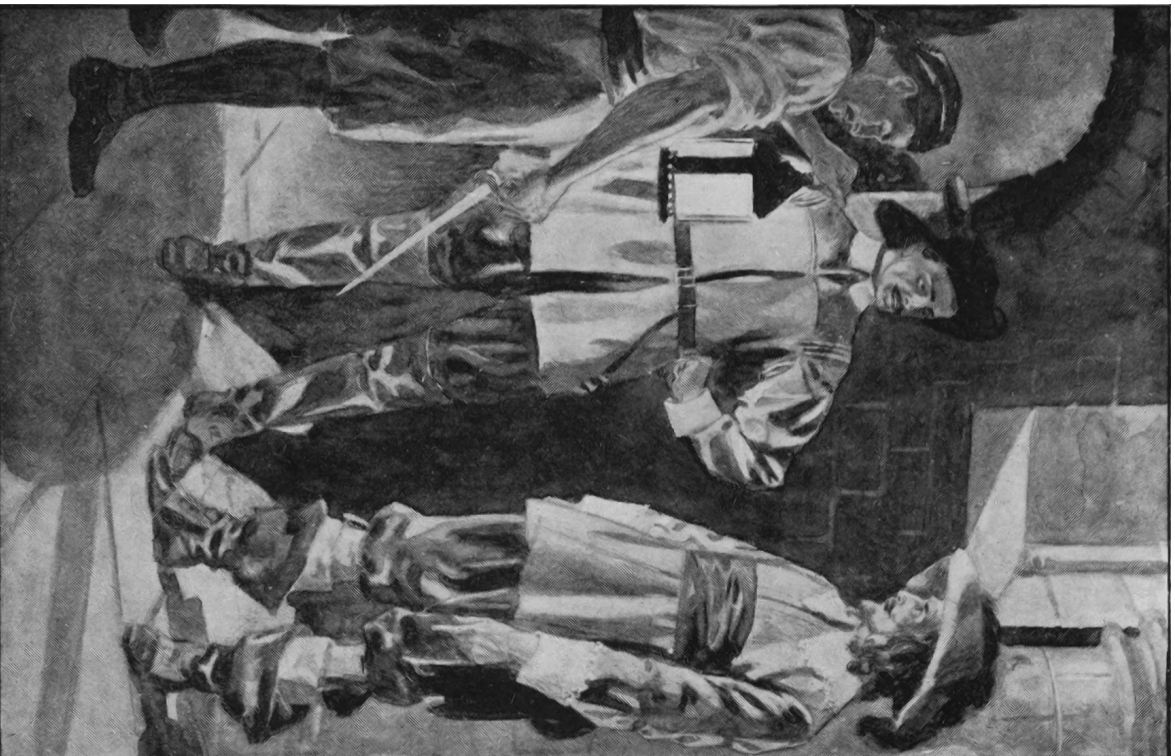
'Blinding his eyes, for instance?'

'To what purpose? He can only see what I desire should be seen; that is to say, that I have around me eleven thousand brave men, who ask no better than to have their throats cut in honour of the parliament of Scotland and England.'

'And this man, my lord?' said Spithead, pointing to the fisherman, who, during this conversation, had remained standing and motionless, like a man who sees but does not understand.

'Ah, that is true,' said Monk. Then turning towards the fisherman,—'I shall see you again, my brave fellow,' said he; 'I have selected a lodging for you. Digby, take him to it. Fear nothing; your money shall be sent to you presently.'

'Thank you, my lord,' said the fisherman, and after having bowed, he left the tent, accompanied by Digby. Before he had gone a hundred paces he found



'THIS, THEN, IS THE SLAB?'